

MIDIAN AND ISHMAEL IN GENESIS 37: Synonyms in the Joseph story

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1. Introduction

1.1 In Genesis 37, the traders who carried Joseph to Egypt are called in some verses מִדְיָנִים or מִדְיָנִים "Midianites",¹ in others יִשְׁמָעֵאֵלִים, "Ishmaelites". The common view across the history of interpretation has been that these names represent distinct groups, raising the question why both are mentioned. The dominant answer in recent times, at least among academics, has been that the two names derive from two different sources, or strands of tradition, which have been combined in this passage.² In the text as it stands, the two names are most easily regarded as alternative designations for the same group, a view presented (among the standard commentaries) by Ibn Ezra, who notes that the term "Ishmaelite" is applied to Midianites in Judg 8:24.³ However, this approach has not been widely followed. Among recent scholars, a part of the reason for this is, no doubt, the fact that other problems are also perceived in this chapter. Westermann mentions not only "different names for the same persons", but also "doublets" and "contradictions" (Westermann 1982, 9). Such perceptions are almost universally held. Even Robert Alter, offered by Whybray (1987, 234) as an example of a scholar who approaches the text as a unity, says that the two literary strands out of which the text is woven seem "awkwardly spliced" in Gen 37:28.⁴ For Whybray, a narrative which was smooth, free from "inconsistencies, contradictions, and unevennesses" was not required by the standards of ancient historiography.⁵ This leaves uncomfortably open the question of the standards by which "ancient historiography" is judged. Would the "narrator" of the Joseph story have agreed that his work showed inconsistencies and contradictions, or does the modern scholar fail to understand his words in the same way as the "implied reader" for whom the text was produced would have done?⁶ Does the modern perception of inconsistencies and contradictions result from failure to understand the ancient conventions, as with a viewer who reads an Egyptian painting as showing a man with two left feet (or two right ones)? Students of modern culture are increasingly suggesting that the perceptions which form the basis for conventional humanist historical views are not the "universals" they have been held to be, but are strongly conditioned by the social and economic conditions in which they originated.⁷ Careful attention to the way Biblical narratives are written has shown that some of the features regarded by "scientific" scholars as the accidental product of error or editorial interference can reasonably be explained as intentional, resulting from the use of particular techniques of narration.⁸

1.2 The view that some wording in Genesis 37 represents "doublets" and "contradictions" results from a choice among possible interpretations. In Gen 37:20, Joseph's brothers suggest

to each other the idea that Joseph be killed and thrown into a pit. In 37:21-22, Reuben argues against shedding blood, but supports the idea that Joseph be thrown into a pit. Reuben intends to send Joseph back to his father, but this is not communicated to his brothers, and, when Reuben's suggestion is acted on (37:23-24), the question of Joseph's ultimate fate is left open. In 37:25, a party of Ishmaelites is observed. Judah suggests that killing Joseph will bring no advantage; he should be sold to the Ishmaelites. His brothers concur (37:26-27). Judah's act can be seen as a separate strand of narrative; it can equally well be seen as building on Reuben's suggestion by adding to it the idea that settles Joseph's hitherto undetermined fate. In 37:28, a party of Midianites comes by. Joseph is pulled up out of the pit and sold to the Ishmaelites, who take him to Egypt. "Is pulled up and sold" here represents *וַיִּמְכְּרוּ וַיַּעֲלוּ... וַיִּמְכְּרוּ*. The referent of the subject pronoun in these 3p. plural active transitive verbs could either be the Midianites, represented by the immediately preceding nominal, or Joseph's brothers, the thematic actors in Gen 37:18-32.⁹ In 37:29-30, Reuben, who has evidently been absent, returns, fails to find Joseph, and expresses his distress at this to his brothers. Reuben is not mentioned in 37:23-28; there is no information on the extent to which he was involved in the events described in those verses. Finally, Gen 37:36 states that the "Medanites" (*הַמִּדְּנִיִּים*) sold Joseph to Egypt, while 39:1 states that Potiphar acquired him from the Ishmaelites. This is part of the basis for the view, offered, e.g., by Rashi, that Joseph was sold many times. However, the word "Medanites" is widely regarded as an alternative form of "Midianites"; both names can be held to designate the same group as does "Ishmaelites".

1.3 It is, then, possible to see doublets and contradictions in these verses, but the wording of the text does not require this. An investigator must either take account of all possibilities, as W. Lee Humphreys suggests,¹⁰ or opt for a set of basic assumptions which will determine the choices made, as Barbara Green, who states that her approach to the question of multiple authorship is determined by the assumptions of interpretation she is offering.¹¹ The latter is, no doubt, the common case with interpreters, whether or not it is openly stated. My own view, foreshadowed above, is that the perception of contradictions etc. in the narrative is most probably the result of defects in our basic assumptions, that is, from our incapacity rather than from that of the narrator. Consequently, I assume that, for him and his intended audience, the story did not include inconsistencies or contradictions. The vendors of Joseph are named as "Medanites" in Gen 37:36, as "Ishmaelites" in 39:1, and as "you" (Joseph's brothers) in Gen 45:4, 5. It could be argued that the last case represents the intention of the brothers, rather than their action.¹² However, it seems clear from 45:5 that Joseph was anxious to remove any feelings of guilt his brothers may have had for their action; it is unreasonable to suppose that he would refer to it if they were not the initial agents of the sale.¹³ By this line of argument, the pronoun in "they pulled up... and sold" (Gen 37:28) must represent Joseph's brothers, and "Midianites", "Medanites" and "Ishmaelites" must be

different names for the same group.¹⁴ The line of thought followed here assumes that the contrasting terms "Midianite/Medanite" and "Ishmaelite" are used with deliberate purpose.

2. Midian and Ishmael as intentional variants.

2.1 The use of variant designations for a population group or an individual is, in fact, common in Biblical narrative. Where it can be shown that each designation is used in a particular context in which the other is not, it is reasonable to argue that the choice of designation is intentional, and makes use of the different connotations carried by the different terms. In this particular case, "Midianites" is used where the noun is subject of its clause, "Ishmaelites" where it is not. This gives at least some basis for the claim that the two terms are used purposefully, with the intention of presenting to the reader different aspects of the same referent.

2.2 Any who notice that "Midianites" and "Ishmaelites" are used with different grammatical functions may well regard this as a meaningless coincidence, especially as the number of examples illustrating it is not large. There is, however, plenty of evidence from the narratives of Judges, Samuel, and Kings, that Biblical narrators deployed alternative designations in just this sort of way to specify the different roles in which a character might interact with others.¹⁵ Where alternative designations are available, it is common for one to be used where the character is agent, as with the traders, who are "Midianites" when travelling, or selling Joseph (Gen 37:28, 36). A contrasting designation is often used where the character is seen from the viewpoint of some other agent, as with the traders, who are "Ishmaelites" where other characters perceive them, or sell to or buy from them (Gen 37:25, 27, 28, 39:1). The term "Midianites" or "Midian" is common in the Bible; it may be taken as the standard classification of the group in terms of Biblical literature. The narrator uses it in Genesis 37 where the group is shown acting alone, without reference to other participants. The term "Ishmaelites" is not common in the Bible.¹⁶ This term is used in this narrative where the group interacts with others, and so can be seen as used to represent their viewpoint. Other sets of synonyms in the stories of Jacob and his sons at the end of the Book of Genesis can be interpreted along similar lines.

3. זונה and קדשה in Genesis 38.

Genesis 38, the story of Judah and Tamar, is scarcely part of the "Joseph Story" in that the events described neither involve Joseph, nor affect his fate. The resumptive repetition in Gen 39:1, however, (cf. 37:36) shows that it was carefully integrated into its present situation, and is an organic part of the narrative in the form in which we have it. In this story, Tamar, pretending to be a prostitute in the prosecution of her plan, is thought by Judah to be a זונה (Gen 38:15), but the Adulammite enquiring about her, and the people who answer him, speak of her as a קדשה (Gen 38:21, 22). זונה, the common biblical term for prostitute, is used by the narrator to present to the reader Judah's perception, on which his acts are based.

The speech of the participants uses the rare term קדשה, representing a woman whose indulgence in extra-marital sex has some cultic basis. The practices represented by the term קדשה were presumably classed among the "abominations of the Canaanites"; this unexpected term can be seen as underlining the fact that the story takes place in a milieu foreign to the society represented by the audience.¹⁷ If this is correct, the use of the term can also be seen as highlighting the depths to which Tamar was willing to risk sinking in her attempt to carry out her duty. The narrator cannot, of course, ensure that such thoughts are evoked in his audience, but they are likely to have been among the complex of ideas which, because they were typically associated with the term קדשה, occasioned its use.¹⁸ The main point for this discussion, however, is simply the fact that the alternative terms are used here with no apparent purpose beyond the conveying of such "expressive nuances".¹⁹

4. שק and אמתחת in Genesis 42-44

These words represent the containers used by Joseph's brothers for transport. כלי appears as a general term, representing containers used by the brothers to transport grain to their families in Canaan (Gen 42:25), or to convey a present to Joseph (43:11). שק and אמתחת both represent a container for provisions for transport or for use en route, a "sack".²⁰ שק is common throughout the Bible. It represents the material "sackcloth" (as in Gen 37:34), or a garment or container made from this.²¹ אמתחת appears only in Genesis 42-44. This term is used in the speech of the participants (Joseph, Gen 44:1, 2; his brothers, 42:28; 43:18, 21, 22; 44:8; his father 43:12; his major domo, 43:23). In addition, the narrator uses it in presenting the perception of one of the brothers: וירא את-כספו והנה הוא בפי אמתחתו (He saw his silver; there it was in the mouth of his sack. Gen 42:27). He also uses it in connection with the searching for Joseph's goblet, and its discovery, in the sacks of his brothers וימקרו ויורדו (Each quickly brought his sack down to the ground, and each opened his sack. The goblet was found in Benjamin's sack. Gen 44:11-12). The term שק is not used in direct speech. The narrator uses it in his indirect representation of the command of Joseph to his major domo (Gen 42:25), in describing the action of one of the brothers which led to the perception quoted above ויפתח (The one opened his sack. Gen 42:27), and where action by the brothers led to a discovery which is described rather than presented as the perception of a character ויהי הם מריקים שקיהם והנה איש צרור-כספו בשקו (Then, as they were emptying their sacks, there was each man's bundle of silver in his sack. Gen 42:35). Thus שק is used where the matter of the sacks and their contents is first raised, and where the narrator presents a somewhat distanced description of events, rather than an immediate narrative involving individuals. The term אמתחת is used where the participants are more immediately involved in the action, characteristically in speech, less commonly elsewhere. In chapter 42, it alternates with שק in such a way as to make it clear that the two are synonyms. Its exclusive use thereafter, especially in chapter 44, where the sacks appear for the last time, has the effect of presenting the events

from the viewpoint of the participants rather than from that of the narrator; it adds immediacy to the narration. There is no evidence that any specific difference in lexical content which may have been carried by the two terms was relevant for the narrative. Here again, a set of synonyms appears to be used solely with the intention of adding expressive nuance to the story.

5. The names Jacob and Israel

5.1 Two designations, Jacob and Israel, are used for Joseph's father. According to Gen 32:29, 35:10, the name "Israel" was to replace "Jacob" from that point on, but both continue in use; "Jacob" is used in about two-thirds of some 115 cases in which the individual is referred to by name. The narrative in chapters 37-50 presents three themes significant for the development of the later community "Israel". The main theme is the descent of the community into Egypt. The other themes are the desirability of burial in the Holy Land, and the inclusion of Ephraim and Manasseh, eponymous fathers of the later tribes, as sons of Jacob "as are Reuben and Simeon" (Gen 48:5). The name "Israel" is used in connection with these three significant themes. The name "Jacob" is used elsewhere. Before Genesis 37, the name "Israel" is used where "Jacob" is possible only in Gen 35:21-22. These examples are discussed in #5.7.²²

5.2 In Genesis 37, the events which culminated in the descent of Jacob and his household into Egypt are introduced in verse 3, which shows that "Israel" favoured Joseph, arousing the hostility of his brothers. "Israel" sent Joseph to Shechem (37:13), a journey which ended, for Joseph, in Egypt. "The ten brothers of Joseph" went down to buy grain in Egypt" (42:3), but it is the sons of "Israel" (b. Israel) who arrive in Egypt (42:5) to buy grain, beginning the events which led to their reunion with Joseph.²³ The name "Israel" is used in the discussion with Judah which results in the inclusion of Benjamin in the second journey of the brothers to Egypt (43:6, 8, 11). After their reunion with Joseph, the "b. Israel" acted on Pharaoh's instructions to fetch their father (45:21), and "Israel" determined to go to Egypt (45:28). "Israel" set out for Beer Sheba (46:1) where God encouraged "Israel" to go to Egypt (46:2). The "b. Israel" conveyed him in the transport provided by Pharaoh (46:5). The "b. Israel" that went to Egypt (including "Jacob") are listed in 46:8. Joseph set out to meet "Israel" on his arrival (46:29), and "Israel's" speech at their reunion is given in 46:30. In וַיֵּשֶׁב יִשְׂרָאֵל ... בְּאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם ... וַיַּאֲחֲזוּ בָהּ (Israel lived in the land of Egypt... and they gained property in it... 47:27) the plural verb shows that the narrator has the community in mind, although he may also have intended to evoke the individual.

5.3 The name "Jacob" is used in Gen 37:1-47:28 where the descent into Egypt is not directly in question. This is true of the preliminaries to the Joseph story in Gen 37:1-2, where "Jacob" tears his garments (37:34), again in the preliminaries to the brothers' first journey into Egypt (42:1, 4), where they return to Canaan (42:29, 45:25), where their father

complains of the loss of his sons (42:36) and where his spirit revives at the thought that Joseph is still alive (45:27). "Jacob" is the name by which God addresses "Israel" (46:2), showing again that "Jacob" is the standard name for the individual. "Jacob" is the name used to represent the individual as a member of the group (46:5b, 6, 8), and in personal relationships (46:8, 15, 18, 19, 22, 25, 26, 27). It is "Jacob" who has an interview with Pharaoh (47:7-10), and the length of whose stay in Goshen, and of his whole life, is given in 47:28. The only puzzling usage, from this viewpoint, is the statement that "Jacob" set out from Beer Sheba (46:5a). However, non-use of the name "Israel" in preliminary material, as in 37:1-2, 42:1-4, seems to be characteristic. This example is immediately followed by a detailed description of the expedition, in which the name "Israel" is used.

5.4 The topic of burial in the Holy Land is opened with "the days of Israel approached dying" (Gen 47:29). After Joseph promised to bury him in the tomb of his fathers, "Israel bowed on the head of the bed" (47:31). After his death, "the doctors embalmed Israel" (50:2) so that he could be taken for burial as requested. At the end of his life, Joseph, in his turn, obtained a promise from the "b. Israel" to take his bones with them when God returns them to the Holy Land, an event he confidently predicts (50:24-25).

5.5 The ceremonial of blessing by which Ephraim and Manasseh become sons of Jacob is treated in Genesis 48. "Jacob" received information that Joseph had come to him, and "Israel" strengthened himself, presumably for the coming ceremonial (48:2). "Jacob" begins his speech with a reference to an earlier encounter with God (48:3, see Gen 35:9). These cases in 48:2, 3, appear to be further examples of the non-use of "Israel" in preliminary matters. The name is used again in "Israel saw the sons of Joseph..." (48:8), and throughout the following description of the ceremonial of blessing (48:10, 11, 13 [2x], 14, 20, 21). "Jacob" is not used until 49:1, where a new scene opens with "Jacob summoned his sons" (to hear his prediction of what is in store for them).

5.6 "Israel" also occurs in the phrase שְׁבִטֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל (49:16, 28), where the name presumably refers to the later community. The only other examples occur in poetic parallel with "Jacob" in 49:2, 7, 24. The primary factor conditioning the use of "Israel" here is literary convention. "Jacob" is not a possible alternative. "Jacob" is used in Gen 47:28-50:26 only in two cases not already mentioned. In 49:33 "Jacob" finishes commanding his sons about his burial and dies. The expression "the land God promised to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob" is used in 50:24.

5.7 It seems clear from the above description that the name "Jacob" is used as the unmarked designation for the individual, while "Israel" is marked, drawing attention to topics of particular importance in the history of the community "Israel" (where it does not actually

represent that community). The use of "Israel" in Gen 35:21-22a can be integrated with this view.²⁴ These verses state that "Israel travelled, and pitched his tent beyond Migdal Eder. When Israel was dwelling in that land, Reuben went and lay with Bilhah, his father's concubine, and Israel heard". Here Jacob embarks on the phase of his travels which eventually led him to Egypt. The twelve sons of Jacob, whom he joined in Egypt, are enumerated in Gen 35:22b-26. Gen 35:27-29 records the coming of Jacob to Isaac his father at "Mamre... where Abraham and Isaac had sojourned", and the death of Isaac. Chapter 36 deals with his brother Esau and his descendants. Genesis 37:1, "Jacob dwelt in the land where his father had sojourned" can be considered as a resumptive repetition of 35:27. It links the initiation of the "descent into Egypt" theme in 35:21-27 to its continuation in chapter 37 in the same way that Gen 39:1 resumes Gen 37:36, linking the narrative around the digression in chapter 38. The material between Gen 35:27 and 37:1, like chapter 38, presents information required for the larger picture which the narrator wishes to present. The context in which it is placed is loosely fitting for it, e.g. in terms of date, but it is not closely related to the specific theme which is the major concern of the narrative in that context.

5.8 The mention of Reuben's misdeed in Gen 49:4 forms an inclusio with its mention in Gen 35:22a and so unites the section of text which covers the three major themes of the Joseph story as far as Jacob is concerned. Gen 49:3-7 present negative comments on Reuben, Simeon, and Levi, the three "tribes" who do not figure as political entities in the settled Israel. It seems reasonable to connect this with the misdeed of Reuben mentioned in 35:22a, and with the mention of Reuben and Simeon as the sons of Jacob to whom Ephraim and Manasseh are to be equivalent (Gen 48:5). Moreover, in the story of Joseph, Reuben twice tries to assume a leadership role, and is twice shown to be inadequate (Gen 37:21-30, 42:37-38). The text does not provide information enough to substantiate these suggested connections, or to prove them misguided. As things are, they provide a sufficient reason to argue that the examples of "Israel" in Gen 35:21-22a form part of the deliberate pattern of usage seen more clearly after Gen 37:1.²⁵

5.9 It is, then, reasonable to argue that, from the point at which the change of Jacob's name is first announced in Gen 32:29, the name "Jacob" continues in use as the unmarked designation for the individual. The marked designation, "Israel", is used to draw attention to the themes of that section of text significant for the development of the historical community Israel from the family of that individual, Jacob. The alternation of the two names results from deliberate choice.

6. The designations used for God

6.1 The designation most commonly used for God in the passages discussed here is אלהים. If the count is begun at Gen 32:1 (to include interesting examples which occur just before the

change in Jacob's name in 32:29), **אלהים** is found to occur in 57 examples, the name of God, **יהוה**, in 13, **אל** in five cases alone (excluding the place name **בֵּית אֵל**), and in four more in combination with **שדי**.

6.2 **אל** "god" is used in speech with the definite article, and followed by words which specify a particular deity, in Gen 35:1 (where God identifies himself to Jacob), 35:3 and 46:3. It is used in similar ways in the names of altars recorded by the narrator in 33:20, 35:7. The combination **אל שדי** is used only in speech. God uses it to identify himself to Jacob in 35:11. Jacob uses it in 43:14 in expressing a wish that God protect his sons, and in 48:3 in designating the deity that appeared to him at Luz (see Gen 35:9 ff). The terms **אל אביך** (God of your father) and **שדי** are used in parallel stichs of poetry in Jacob's blessing of Joseph (Gen 49:25).

6.3 **יהוה** "Yahweh", the name commonly used in the Bible as a specific designation for the God of Israel, is used as a vocative by Jacob addressing God in Gen 32:10 and 49:18. In the first case, Jacob is praying to "the God of my father Abraham and the God of my father Isaac", expressing thanks for benefits received, and requesting protection from Esau. The example in Gen 49:18, **לִישׁוּעָתְךָ יְהוֹהִי יְהוֹהִי** (I have waited for your salvation, O Yahweh), appears as an aside within Jacob's blessings of his sons; it is often suggested that this is a gloss.²⁶ Aside from these two cases, the name **יהוה** is used only in narration, and only in chapters 38 and 39. Where the narrator uses this name, God appears as manager of human affairs, without any suggestion of personal relationship with those managed. Matters are **רע** **יהוה** **בעיני יהוה** (evil in the sight of the Yahweh, 38:7, 10) with the result that "Yahweh killed him" (Er, 38:7). Yahweh is "with" (**את**) Joseph (39:2, 3, 21, 23), bringing success to (**מצליח**) whatever Joseph undertook (39:3, 23). This idea is doubly recapitulated in Gen 39:5 in the statement that, for the sake of Joseph, Yahweh blessed (**ויברך**) the house of the Egyptian (Potiphar), and the blessing of Yahweh was on all that he possessed.

6.4 **אלהים** "god" is used in narration in 13 cases (two more than **יהוה**). **אלהים** speaks to Jacob (Gen 35:1, 10, 11, 15) and to Israel (Gen 46:2), appears to Jacob (35:9), leaves him (35:13). In 35:7, the narrator refers to "the **אלהים** who appeared (pl) to Jacob when he fled from Esau (see Gen 28:12-15)". The angels who encounter Jacob in 32:2 are called "messengers (**מלאכי**) of **אלהים**". The "fear of **אלהים**" prevents the local population from pursuing the sons of Jacob (35:5). Jacob sacrifices to "the **אלהים** of his father" (46:1). The name "the **אלהים** of Israel" specifies the **אל** for whom an altar is named in 33:20. The objects given up by his household to Jacob for disposal in his preparation for his journey to Luz are called **אלהי הנכר** "the foreign **אלהים**" (35:4).

6.5 Some form of the noun **אלהים** is used in speech in 44 examples. Jacob requests that his household gives up their "foreign **אלהים**" in 35:2, using the same term as does the narrator. Elsewhere, the construct form is used in various phrases identifying the God worshipped by Jacob and his family. "God of my father Abraham and God of my father Isaac" is used as a vocative along with the name Yahweh in Gen 32:10, as noted above. "God of your father" is used by God in identifying himself to Israel (46:3), and by Jacob, in making the request of Joseph reported by his brothers (50:17). "God of your fathers" is used to Joseph's brothers by his major domo, who precedes it with "your God" (43:23 x2). The absolute form, **אלהים**, is used alone by Jacob and his family among themselves or to foreigners in 27 cases,²⁷ by an angel to Jacob (32:29) and by Pharaoh to his servants and to Joseph (41:38, 39). **אלהים** is used with the definite article by Joseph and his brother among themselves to designate the divine power which controls their fate (42:18, 44:16, 45:8), and also by Jacob in blessing Joseph (48:15 x2), where it has modifiers specifying the power as that before which Abraham and Isaac walked, and which shepherds Jacob.

6.6 This survey suggests that the best English equivalent of **אלהים** might be "divinity", whether this is seen as representing a being, a "god", or as representing an abstract idea, "divineness" or "divine power", used euphemistically to avoid a more specific reference to a God.²⁸ The latter seems the preferable choice; **אל** is clearly used to denote an individual representative of divinity, and languages tend to avoid needless duplication.²⁹

6.7 **אל** and **אלהים** are the words typically used where humans speak of God in the section studied: **אלהים** representing (according to the view taken here) divine power in general; **אל** representing an individual representative of it.³⁰ The narrator uses **אלהים** to designate divine power from the point of view of his human characters. **אלהים** is the power which appears to, and communicates with, these individuals, to which they direct their actions, and which humans in general fear. **יהוה** is the name used for this power when the narrator represents his own viewpoint. In narrative passages, **יהוה** is the God responsible for the fate of Jacob and his descendants when not shown as personally involved with them, and so not shown from their viewpoint.

6.8 The name **יהוה** is used twice as a vocative by Jacob. **אלהים** is also used in this way, but only when accompanied by expressions which identify the individual representative of divine power who is addressed. **אל שדי** is the name used by Jacob when speaking to his family of the God they worship. It is also used by that God when speaking to Jacob. From a synchronic standpoint, it seems to be simply a less "personal" term than **יהוה**, standing in the same sort of relation to that name as does **אלהי ישראל**. **יהוה** is used by Jacob only in prayer, reflecting the closest personal relationship with God.

6.9 The two designations יהוה and אל שדי are, then, used in quite distinct situations. Unfortunately, the number of examples is too small to justify the placing of any reliance on conclusions drawn from this fact.³¹ In the same way, the survey of this small section cannot claim any particular significance for the question of the value of the designations for God in the Book of Genesis (let alone the Bible) as a whole. The purpose here is to show that, within this section, it is reasonable to argue that the designations used for God have distinct values. Other arguments may be equally reasonable. If so, they also are possible as explanations of the situation. The argument here is only that deliberate use of these terms with distinct values is, itself, a possible explanation.

7. Summary and conclusion

7.1 In the case of each of these sets of "other synonyms", it is reasonable to interpret the use of the synonyms as the deliberate choice of different words to represent the same referent so as to use effectively some specific value of each word. Since the different sets are in different semantic fields, the precise purpose of the choice differs somewhat in each set. In Gen 38, זונה, the common term in the Bible and later, which is used first, presents Judah's categorization of Tamar in her assumed role unequivocally. קדשה, the marked term used by the other characters in the narrative, shows that the events described occur in an environment foreign to that of the narrator, and possibly also highlights the seriousness of the course undertaken by Tamar. In Genesis 42-44, שק represents the narrator's viewpoint, אמתחת, that of the characters in the narrative. The latter term is used by the narrator in 42:27 to present vividly the perception of one of the characters, and in 44:11, 12, at a critical point in the narrative, to describe the searching for Joseph's goblet in his brothers' sacks, where, as the audience knows, Joseph has had it put. The narrator thus abandons his distanced stance, his non-involvement with the events of the narrative, and so heightens the immediacy of those events for the audience. It seems probable that שק was the common word for the object, at least in the narrator's day, while אמתחת was uncommon. If this is the case, the initial use of שק identifies the referent clearly, while the use of אמתחת again draws attention to the unfamiliar environment in which the events take place. From Gen 32:29 on, the name "Jacob" continues in use as an unmarked designation for the individual who was originally given that name. The name "Israel" (where it represents that individual) is used to draw attention to the process by which God transforms this individual's family from the mundane "children" or "household" of the man, Jacob, to the unique (children of) "Israel". Throughout the same section of text, the common designation of God in the Bible generally, the name Yahweh, represents the narrator's view, and is used where he takes a distanced stance in describing the events. אלהים is the usual term used by the characters to refer to God. The narrator uses it when presenting the narrative from their point of view, giving, as with his use of אמתחת, the impression of closer involvement in the events described, and so adding to their immediacy for the audience. אלהים is non-specific, and has a general mean-

ing, possibly "divine power". אל (and מלאך אלהים) represents an individual representative of that non-specific concept. אל שדי is the name usually used by Jacob and his family for the particular representative that they worship. יהוה is used by Jacob in addressing God at critical junctures. It can be seen as the expression of his closest relationship with God, and so as adding to the impact of the narrative.

7.2 It seems, then, that, in each case, one term is used to represent the viewpoint of the narrator; synonyms are used to emphasize the gap between the world of the implied reader and that of the events recorded, and to add to the impact of the narrative in the specific ways described. The question of the specific value of these terms in any historical period has little relevance. It is quite possible (for instance) that אלהים was not the common designation for God in the period represented by the narrative, but was, in the narrator's day, outside his own community. Its value in the narrative depends principally on the fact that it was not the term commonly used by the narrator and his audience, possibly supported by their ideas on earlier usage. Whether these ideas were historically accurate or not is of little importance for the understanding of the use of the word in the text.

7.3 It is reasonable to interpret the use of the terms "Midianite" and "Ishmaelite" as representing the same pattern. "Midianite", the common Biblical term, represents the narrator's attitude of distance, of non-involvement in the events described. "Ishmaelite" represents the viewpoint of the characters in the narrative. It seems likely that this was the term used in the narrator's world for people living in more or less the area occupied by the Biblical "Midianites".³² If so, as with זונה, it represents the common term, used first, making the circumstances clear.³³ "Midianite" represents the world familiar to the narrator and his audience from the Bible. The contrasting terms can be seen as used to highlight the distance between the world of the narrative and that of the narrator. They would also carry any connotations characteristic of their use in the narrator's day, but these, whatever their importance, can be little more than a subject of speculation.

7.4 These views raise questions about the sources of the last eighteen chapters of Genesis. It is possible that each synonym in each set originated in a different source.³⁴ It seems unlikely, however, that their use in the text as it stands is directly copied from such sources. Westermann (1982, 118, on Gen 42:27-28) notes the difficulty of treating שק and אמתחת in this way. It is equally difficult to see any reason why the names in the statement that אלהים said to Israel... 'Jacob, Jacob' ... (Gen 46:2) should represent different sources.³⁵ The alternatives appear to be that the names, whatever their origin, are chosen to suit the purposes of the narrator, or that the choice is unmotivated. Since the text has mentioned the change of Jacob's name twice, unmotivated variation could scarcely have arisen unless through scribal error. Since it does appear reasonable to see a pattern of usage, the sugges-

tion that the choice was deliberate is also reasonable.³⁶ Books are typically written to carry a message to the writer's day, whether they deal with matters contemporary with him, or with earlier times. It is difficult to imagine that a writer with this purpose (and this purpose is typically ascribed to Biblical writings except where a critic sees careless admixture of sources) would routinely impede the presentation of his message by using, unchanged, wording originally formulated for a different audience in a different period.³⁷ Literary sources are typically used in new works through adaptation, not through preservation. It is difficult to explain the use of the names "Israel" and "Jacob" in Gen 46:2 above, or of קְדָשָׁה in Genesis 38, other than as deliberately chosen for their position in the text as it stands. The use of "Midianite" and "Ishmaelite" and the other sets of synonyms surveyed here can reasonably be treated in the same way.

7.5 I would like to think that the view that such treatment is "reasonable" would not be restricted to those who share my basic assumptions (see #1.3 above). Most scholars appear content to assume that, despite his obvious skill as a story-teller, the narrator did not care about the problems he created, or did not notice them.³⁸ Occasional inconsistency can reasonably be excused in this way; Homer, too, is said to nod. As used, however, the assumption ascribes procedures to the narrator which are hard to reconcile. For example, he must be seen as so precise in his attention to grammar that the referent of the pronoun in "they pulled Joseph up out of the pit" in Gen 37:28 must be represented by the closest suitable nominal, and so must be the Ishmaelites. At the same time, the narrator must be seen as so indifferent to the effect of his presentation of participants that he introduces the Midianites for the first time in 37:28 in the same way as, in 37:29, he reintroduces Reuben, who was leading participant in 37:21-22. If "Midianites" here represents a new participant, with all the consequences for the narrative that that would carry, the failure to mark its introduction by any form of highlighting, such as is supplied for the Ishmaelites in 37:25, is certainly surprising.³⁹ The common view that the text as received is the work of a master storyteller, who, however, often made obvious mistakes, is not easy to accept considering the probable length of time that the narrative was in circulation before careful attention was given to the prevention of changes in it. We all have to blush for our own oversights, but the picture that this view requires of inconsistency and crass error in the original of the narrative we have (whether seen as the product of an individual or of successive editors), and of the indifference to this of the tradents and their audience, seems unduly patronizing. Perhaps my own view of the narrator is unduly idealistic. I would like to think, however, that further close study of the way that language is used in the narratives will show that the narrator's work was more self-consistent than the common view of his work admits, and that his use of "Midianites" and "Ishmaelites" in Genesis 37 is an example of this.

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1. The two forms are presumed to be alternative spellings for the name of the same group, see Eph'al 1982, 61, 236.
2. The use of two names may be seen as the purposeless result of the combination of different accounts by editors indifferent to such inconsistency, or simply incompetent. It may be seen as purposeful: "The narrator of the Joseph story obviously intends to let his listeners know that he has at his disposal two versions of how Joseph came down to Egypt, and will let both speak" (Westermann 1982, 32). Both views, then, see the preservation of traditions as a higher priority in the formation of the text than the presentation of a particular view of events. This seems to me a highly dubious assumption; explicit methods of dealing with such a situation ("others say...", ...אומרים...), are easily devised. Westermann does discuss motivation on p. 34. However, even if his suggestion is considered as justifying the presentation, intertwined, of differing (but equally valid) accounts of the same events, what is more seriously needed is evidence that such techniques were common enough that the audience could be expected to understand them in the way that Westermann believes was intended.
3. Some later scholars take the same view, as Thomas Staubli, who speaks of the Midianites and Ishmaelites as appearing in Genesis 37:25-28 as traders, and adds "As in Judges 6-8, so also here Midianites and Ishmaelites are identified, since these different names at different times denoted the same population group for Israelites." (Staubli 1991, 200). He suggests that the use of two names is to be ascribed to "The actualizing, glossing and generalizing rereading of an older account (and probably not the interweaving of two sources)". For Biblical commentators who see the terms as referring to the same group, see Wenham 1994, 355.
4. Alter 1996, 214. For Alter, the Midianites pulled Joseph from the pit and sold him to the Ishmaelites in Gen 37:28, but elsewhere these two names designate the same people, as in Judg. 8:22, 24.
5. Whybray 1987, 242. This view of the Genesis narrative accords well with the finding that "Genesis appears to be more or less of one piece", but presents many puzzling details (Radday-Shore 1985, 217).
6. In this paper, the term "narrator" represents those who produced the Hebrew text in what was (but for minor accidents, such as scribal error) its received form. The "implied reader" is a personification of the audience for whom that text was originally intended.
7. See, e.g. John Hadyn Baker's review of Dierdre Schauna Lynch The Economy of Character: Novels, market culture, and the business of inner meaning in The Times Literary Supplement, August 28, 1988, p. 25.
8. E.g. the repetition in 1 Kgs 20:16-19, once commonly viewed in this way, is recognized by Burke O. Long as deliberate resumption for literary purposes. See Long 1985, note 3.
9. The Biblical narrator may use a pronoun to refer to an established theme despite potential ambiguity, as with וישת (he drank, Judg 15:19), וישב וישלח (he sent again, 2 Kgs 1:11, 13), ויקרא... ויאמר (he called... and said, 2 Kgs 4:36). The verbs in each of these cases represent a reaction by the subject, a thematic actor in the passage, to an action by another, who is represented by a nominal which (in terms of number and gender) is the closest possible antecedent of the pronouns in the verbs quoted. The reaction is predictable from the narrative context.

The same is true of *וימכרו ויעלו*... in Gen 37:28 if the pronouns refer to Joseph's brothers. The accentuation (whatever its relation to the narrator's intention) marks the same disjunction between the previous clause and this passage as between the first clause in Judg 15:19 and what follows.

10. "Attempts to explain the condition of the text in terms of two sources can only tell us how what we have received was formed, and not how we are to read what we have before us." (Humphreys 1988, 36)

11. Green 1996, 54 and 59 n. 40. She regards the uncertainty about the precise roles of Midianites and Ishmaelites as intentional: designed to encourage the reader to consider the full range of responsibility for Joseph's situation.

12. As with "He (Reuben) saved him (Joseph) from their hands" in Gen 37:21. However, this is a use of the so-called "conative imperfect" depicting (intended) action on the main narrative line, in the reader's past, but in the participants' present. It is doubtful that the use of a perfect form representing an event in the speaker's past (as in Gen 45:4, 5) could have the same value. My own view is that the subject of the verb here represents the persons responsible for the action, rather than the actual agents, a usage common in Hebrew as in English: "Uzziah built towers in Jerusalem" (2 Chron 26:9).

13. It could reasonably be argued that, if he had been pulled from the pit by the Midianites, Joseph would not even know that his brothers had planned to sell him. I do not understand Westermann's claim that his explanation (that verses 25b, 26, 27, 28b form "a variant... inserted into this narrative" presented by the other material), is "confirmed" by the fact that Gen 40:15 and 45:4 leave it "an open question how Joseph came down" to Egypt (Westermann 1982, 32). It seems much more reasonable to argue that Gen 45:4-5 shows that the brothers were responsible for the sale of Joseph into Egypt, and that the identity of the middlemen they used was unimportant, raising again the question of why any effort should have been made to preserve the names of two distinct groups of middlemen.

14. It might be argued that the view (originating in the Midrash) that Joseph was sold a number of times is supported by Gen 37:36 and 39:1. However, if the narrator intended to show this, the wording chosen was highly unconventional. The adoption, by so many Rabbinic commentators, of the view that "Midianites" and "Ishmaelites" represent different groups, was perhaps conditioned by their views on how the Bible uses words. The view that the names represent the same group is, to my mind, supported by the fact that Gen 39:1 presents resumptive repetition of 37:36, signalling resumption of the Joseph narrative after the digression in chapter 38. Thus Talmon, who presents this view fully, sees "Ishmaelites" and "Midianites" are seen as "both equivalent to 'caravan traders'" (Talmon 1978, 18-19), and Adele Berlin, who follows Talmon's view of the function of Gen 39:1, sees "Midianites" as a hyponym of "Ishmaelites" (Berlin 1983, 76, 120). If the two names do not represent the same group, such a sharp divergence in the repeated information needs explanation.

15. This is the main concern of Revell 1996. Usage typical for the designation of a ruler (the most common example) is outlined there in #5.4.1. The treatment of groups can be observed in the use of singular or plural designators for Israel, the tribes, etc. Plural appears to be used where the group is more prominent in the narra-

tive, typically as agent, singular otherwise. The brief description there in #16 is based on a more extensive study accepted for MAARAV in 1992, but not yet available.

16. "Ishmaelite" is used in Judg 8:24 to explain a specific characteristic of people otherwise called "Midianite". In Ps 83:7, God is exhorted to take action against a group of nations striving to destroy Israel among whom "Edom and Ishmaelites" are listed first. "Midian" is mentioned in v. 10 in a historical context, listed along with Sisera, Jabin, Oreb and Zeeb, and Zebah and Zalmunna as exemplifying God's past victories, a parallel of which is now needed. The Chronicler uses the gentilic "Ishmaelite" as an epithet for Amasa's father (1 Chron 2:17), and for David's overseer of camels (1 Chron 27:30). In these cases (particularly Genesis 37 and Judg 8:24) "Beduin" might be a suitable English equivalent for "Ishmaelites". Elsewhere, "Ishmael" appears only as the name of an individual.

17. The term קְדִישָׁה is used in Genesis 38, in Deut 23:18 in interdicting the presence of the class in Israel, and also (in the plural) in Hos 4:14 in the context of improper forms of worship and the abandoning by the people of their God (although various forms derived from the root זָנָה are used much more freely in this passage). Prof. Dion (1981) has suggested that cultic prostitution was only a memory in Judah by the time of the Chronicler, but, as he points out, there is no knowing when it effectively disappeared.

18. This view assumes, of course, that the story in its present form was intended to be understood in the thought-world represented by Deut 23:18, so that the activities of a קְדִישָׁה were considered more reprehensible than those of a זֹנֶה. Esther Marie Menn provides an extensive and erudite discussion of the two terms (Menn 1997, 64-73). She suggests that קְדִישָׁה functions as a "loosely synonymous term" for זֹנֶה (p. 68), but, with scholarly restraint, makes no decision on the narrator's intention in using both. The common view sees קְדִישָׁה as "the more polite designation" (Westermann 1982, 48) which "recalls the sacred meaning of the practice" (von Rad 1956, 315), or as a "euphemism" (Wenham 1994, 368). Such views may well have been common in ancient Israel, but it seems unreasonable to interpret the story in terms of its (putative) origin without regard to its actual context -- a book intended for use in a society which tolerated the זֹנֶה, but not (officially) the קְדִישָׁה -- and without consideration of the point at which that work ceased to undergo change.

19. The word קְדִישָׁה is used to evoke the connotations it carries (whether these are seen as mitigating the use of זֹנֶה or not), not to convey the specific meaning "cultic prostitute" which it (presumably) denotes. Thus Richard A. Henshaw pines "Qēdešāh seems to be a synonym for zōnāh here". (Henshaw 1994, 244).

20. This is the common opinion. Jonas Greenfield (1965) suggested "load, pack" as the meaning of אִמְתַּחַת. He argues that אִמְתַּחַת and שָׂק are "obviously distinct" in Gen 42:27, but, if this is accepted, the verse suggests that the אִמְתַּחַת is contained within the שָׂק, and has a "mouth", neither of which accords well with his view that אִמְתַּחַת is, at least etymologically, equivalent to מִשָּׂא. Sarna concludes that אִמְתַּחַת denotes a smaller pack within a larger sack. (Sarna 1989, 296.) This suits well in Gen 42:27, but comparison of Gen 42:25 with Gen 44:1 could be held to suggest that like אִמְתַּחַת, כֶּלִי has a meaning more general than "provision bag". What is impor-

tant here is the lack of any indication that knowledge of the specific meanings of the two words would add to our understanding of the events of the narrative.

21. Outside the Joseph story, **קש** represents a container in Jos 9:4, and possibly Lev 11:32. The word is widely used in other Semitic languages with the same range as in Hebrew.

22. "Israel" is used to represent the individual, of necessity, in connection with the name change (Gen 32:29, 35:10). In Gen 32:33, 33:20, 34:7, 36:21, it represents the (later) community, not an individual.

23. Gen 42:4 states that Benjamin was not sent with the ten. After this aside, 42:5 is linked to 42:3 by resumptive repetition. From this point on, where any group formed from Joseph and his brothers is designated by the patronymic, "b. Israel" is typically used, evoking the idea of the later community, even though this may not be intended in the narrative context. Designations other than "sons of Jacob" are used to contrast with "sons of Israel", as in Gen 42:3. However, the "wives of the sons of Jacob" are mentioned in Gen 46:26, in the summary of the list of the b. Israel who came to Egypt (46:8), where the individual "Jacob" is the specific referent (see #5.3 below).

24. The use of a space, a **pisqah ba'emsaf pasuq** following Gen 35:22a presumably reflects the fact that some strand of early scholarly tradition saw a significant division of content there. See Segal 1960).

25. In fact, the section in question should probably be seen as beginning at 35:9, with the appearance of God to reiterate the announcement of the change of Jacob's name, and the promise of the Land. It is quite clear that, although "The Jacob Cycle" may end with Genesis 35, the material in the "cycle" is not devoid of links with the following chapters. See, e.g., Westermann 1982, 8-9; Coats 1983, 264.

26. Either confidently, as Westermann (1982, 268), or with circumspection, as von Rad (1956, 373).

27. Jacob uses it in speaking to Esau (Gen 33:5, 10, 11), and with no addressee indicated (32:3, 31). Israel uses it in speaking to Joseph (48:11, 21) and in blessing his sons (48:20). Joseph uses it to Potiphar's wife (39:9), to Pharaoh's ministers (40:8), and to Pharaoh himself (41:16, 25, 28, 32 x2), to his brothers (43:29, 45:5, 7, 9, 50:19, 20, 24, 25) and to his father (48:9), and, with no addressee indicated, when naming his sons (41:51, 52). In 42:28, the brothers use it to each other.

28. What is here envisaged as "euphemism" is the practice of using a distanced reference to a power from fear that specific reference might have undesirable consequences. Practice of this sort is endemic in the deferential language common in Biblical Hebrew (see Revell 1996, #20) and in the later development of Judaism, where the prime example is, of course, the use of surrogates for the name of God.

29. Other abstract ideas are also represented by nouns in "masculine plural" form. See Waltke-O'Connor 1990, #7.4.2. It is easy to envisage a process through which this abstract term, through being constantly used (in origin "euphemistically") for the God of Israel, would come to be viewed, and so used, as meaning "a god" or "God", eventually supplanting **אל**. The fact that "honorific plurals" (of which **אלהים** is the dominant example in Biblical Hebrew as we have it, see *ibid.* #7.4.3) were used in the language may have contributed to the process.

30. Either word may be used in certain situations. The claim here is simply that they carry different connotations.

31. The situation is similar for source critics who assign יהוה to J and אל שרי to P. J is considered to be quite heavily involved in the passages surveyed here. Why, then, is the use of יהוה so limited? And what peculiarity of the sources resulted in the use of P's designation at those particular points?

32. Thus George E. Mendenhall (1992) suggests that the alternation of "Midianites" and "Ishmaelites" in Genesis 37 is "probably to be explained by the fact that at the time when the narrative reached its present form, the Midianites had ceased to exist as distinct social group but were identified with an ethnic group later called the Ishmaelites". "Ishmaelites" have been identified in extra-biblical sources from the 8th century BC on, particularly in Assyrian records of the 7th century. See Knauf 1992.

33. In fact, the term that was the common designation in the narrator's day appears to be used first in all the sets of synonyms considered. With זונה (and יעקב) this is also the term most commonly used in Biblical Hebrew with the meaning in question. With שק (and אלהים), and with ישמעלים, some other term is more commonly used to designate the referent in question (provision sack, God of Israel, transjordanian tribesmen). The historical background of the usage is, of course, different in each case.

34. This is often suggested for the proper nouns, rarely for the common ones.

35. Traditionally אלהים represents E or P, "Israel", J, and "Jacob", E.

36. Of course this can only be a generalization. Where a word requires special explanation, the one provided may be valid. If not valid, this may be due either to inadequate understanding of the usage, or to the fact that the original pattern has not persisted unchanged.

37. Even if the same perlocutionary effect, the same result, was intended, writers from different periods who had different audiences in view, and used different texts, must necessarily use different illocutionary means, different wording.

38. Carolin Papp puts this sort of view about as gently as is possible, seeing the Joseph story as "...a masterpiece of narrative art, but nevertheless as a human product, with small errors and inconsistencies" (Papp 1995, 171). However, many would see the use of the adjective "small" as meiosis. Thus von Rad, who speaks of "mastery of the material" which shows "very superior artistry", also sees "a serious discrepancy in the narrative, which disturbs even the untrained reader" (von Rad 1956, 304). Certainly, if "Ishmaelites" and "Midianites" designate different groups, the use of the one term in Gen 39:1 in the resumptive repetition of 37:26, where the other is used seems more than a minor inconsistency (see n. 14).

39. Wenham makes this point, appealing for support to the work of R. Longacre (Wenham 1994, 355).